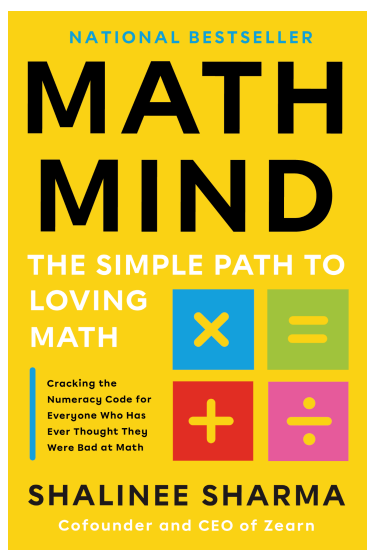




STUDY GUIDE

Math Mind Shalinee Sharma

This study guide is designed to spark meaningful discussions among educators about Shalinee Sharma's national bestseller, “Math Mind: The Simple Path to Loving Math.” Together, you’ll bust common math myths, explore why math matters now more than ever, and dive into practical strategies to help all kids succeed.

This guide includes a set of questions suitable for groups of any size. For the most engaging experience, try breaking into smaller groups of 4-5 so everyone has a chance to share their thoughts. You’ll find enough questions for about two hours of discussion — feel free to cover everything in one session or spread it out over several.

All you need to join the discussion is to have read “Math Mind.” If you haven’t had a chance to read yet, you can still engage in the discussion. Below are some quick-read interviews and articles to get you up to speed. Just grab a pen and paper for notes, and you’re ready to dive in!

Resources to Engage with Math Mind

If you haven’t read “Math Mind: The Simple Path to Loving Math,” the following resources, which address key takeaways, are available to help you participate in the discussion.



TIME Magazine: “The Myth of the Math Kid,” (6 minute read)

Dive into Shalinee’s TIME op-ed, which challenges the myth that math is only for some people and how shifting mindsets can help every kid find success in math, no matter their starting point.



ParentData podcast: “Every Kid is a Math Kid,” (45 minute listen)

Shalinee joins Professor Emily Oster to discuss how misconceptions about math prevent many students from reaching their full potential. Hear actionable advice for parents and educators to help every kid excel in math.



Next Big Idea Club magazine: “An Education Expert Shares Simple Secrets to Loving Math,” (10 minute listen)

Tune into this audio summary of “Math Mind” to discover key strategies that make math more accessible and enjoyable for all students. Shalinee offers quick, practical tips for developing a love of math.

The Myths

Bust the three myths that hold us back from learning and loving math.

Opening question

- Were there any insights you took from “Math Mind” or the related resources that challenged your beliefs about math learning? If so, what were they and why?

Myth 1: Speed is everything

- Reflect on your own math learning experiences: Did speed play a role in your perception of math success?
- How do you balance encouraging a slower, thoughtful approach to problem-solving with the need for fluency? Do you face tradeoffs when trying to foster both fluency and deeper understanding, and how do you prioritize these in your instruction and choices?

Myth 2: Tricks are the answer

- Share examples of math ‘tricks’ you may have experienced yourself or seen students using. How did these affect students' understanding of underlying concepts?
- What adjustments might it require to teach the reasoning behind common math tricks? What are the benefits of this approach, and how would you balance that with other demands in your classroom?

Myth 3: There is only one right way

- What’s the most creative math solution a student has surprised you with? What was the outcome?
- How can you encourage students to focus on problem-solving rather than “answer-getting” in math?

The Methods to Learn and Love Math

Explore and apply the five methods to make math rigorous and accessible for all kids.

Opening question

- What is your vision for math learning in your classroom? How might the insights shared in “Math Mind” and the related resources help to support this vision?

Method 1: Believe

- Reflect on your own experience learning math as a student. Did you see yourself as a “math kid”? Do you see yourself as a “math person” now? Why or why not?
- What strategies might you use to bust the myth of the “math kid” and instead foster a mindset that all kids can succeed in math?

Method 2: Use pictures and objects

- Share an example of a lesson in which you use visual representations or manipulatives to explain a math concept. How do these tools help students gain a deeper understanding of the material?
- Considering potential constraints such as limited time or resources, how might you integrate more visual representations and manipulatives in your current math lessons?

Method 3: Make an easier problem

- Consider the problem 35×18 . Write down the first step you would take to solve the problem, then share aloud with the group. Were there differences in your approaches? How might you have simplified the problem to make it easier to solve?
- How can you encourage students to look for easier ways to solve math problems, and what challenges might you face in allowing for varied approaches?

Method 4: Try a different way

- Think of a time when a student struggled to solve a math problem using a particular method, but the concept clicked when they were shown another way. How did it affect their engagement and understanding?
- How do you manage lessons where students are encouraged to use multiple problem-solving approaches, especially in a large class where it’s challenging to provide individual guidance?

Method 5: Practice with purpose

- What are the biggest challenges you encounter in ensuring math practice is purposeful and engaging? How might you tackle those challenges?
- What is the role of technology in practice, and how can it support or detract from purposeful learning?

The Numeracy Ideal and Realities

Discuss the importance of numeracy for all students and address roadblocks to achieving this goal.

Opening question

- Individually write down a few times that you can remember using math in your daily life over the past week (outside of teaching), then share with the group. How long were your lists? Were there any answers that surprised you?

The importance of numeracy

- Discuss how societal perceptions of who can succeed in math influence students. How can you as an educator work to shift these perceptions?

Identify roadblocks

- What challenges might you face in implementing the methods described in “Math Mind,” that you haven’t yet discussed, both in your school’s specific context and systemically? How might you begin to address these challenges?

Conclusion

If you broke into smaller groups, return to the full group at the end of your discussion to solidify next steps. Each person should take a few minutes to write down 1-2 insights – or more if you’re feeling inspired – from their discussions that resonated with them the most. Volunteers can share aloud with the group.

Next, as a group decide on a few actionable next steps that you can all take to begin applying the insights you shared. In future meetings, share updates about your progress: which strategies are working and in which areas do team members need more support.

Thank you for the work you are doing to help all kids succeed in math. All kids are math kids!